

How to Format an MLA Paper in Microsoft Word Online

The formatting standards of the Modern Language Association (MLA) are what all English classes require when formatting papers for submission. These formatting standards aim to make papers uniform and easy to read. By following the steps outlined below, you will ensure your paper aligns with MLA format and earns full credit for the formatting criteria on the grading rubric.

The basic checklist for MLA format calls for:

- ☐ 12-point legible font (Times New Roman, Calibri, and Helvetica are recommended)
- ☐ Double Spaced paragraphs
- ☐ Paragraphs indented by one Tab press
- ☐ 1-inch margins
- ☐ Proper MLA Header
- ☐ Page numbers in the top right corner of each page
- ☐ Paper title centered in plain face font
 - ☐ Use title case

Thankfully, many of these steps are the defaults in Microsoft Word Online. The following guide will be working in Word Online. I recommend that you complete all your classwork using Word Online; it automatically saves your work and allows for easy sharing of feedback with myself or co-teachers.

Reviewing and completing the steps on this checklist should be the last step before submitting to Turnitin.com. Return to this guide once your assignments are completed and follow the steps.

Ready? Let's begin.

The Basics

MLA Header

The MLA header needs four pieces of information:

1. Your Name
2. Teacher's Name
3. Class
4. Due Date (Month Day, Year)

Stu Dent

Mr. Sanna

Honors English 9

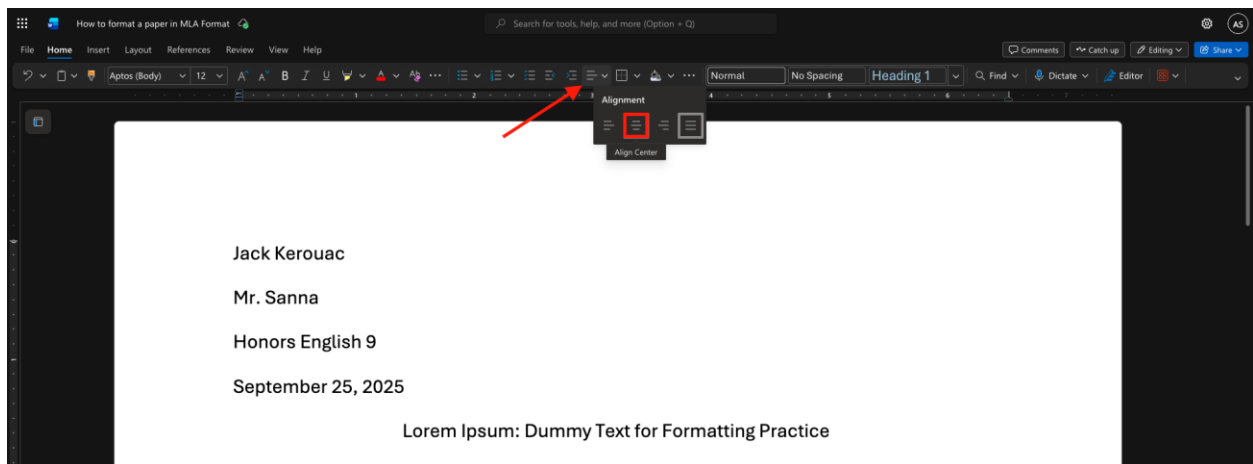
September 25, 2025

This header is the first piece of writing in your paper, and it goes in the body of the document. **It does not go in the header section of the document; we will take care of that step later.**

Title of Paper

The title of your paper should be short and clear; for our purposes, aim for between 6-10 words. Do not **Bold**, *Italicize*, Underline, or change the **size of the font**.

Press “Enter” on your keyboard to begin a new line, then center the text on the page.



Type your title in Title Case.

Capitalize	Do not Capitalize
• First and Last word of the title • Nouns & Verbs • Adjectives & Adverbs • Pronouns	• Articles (a, an, the) • Conjunctions • Prepositions

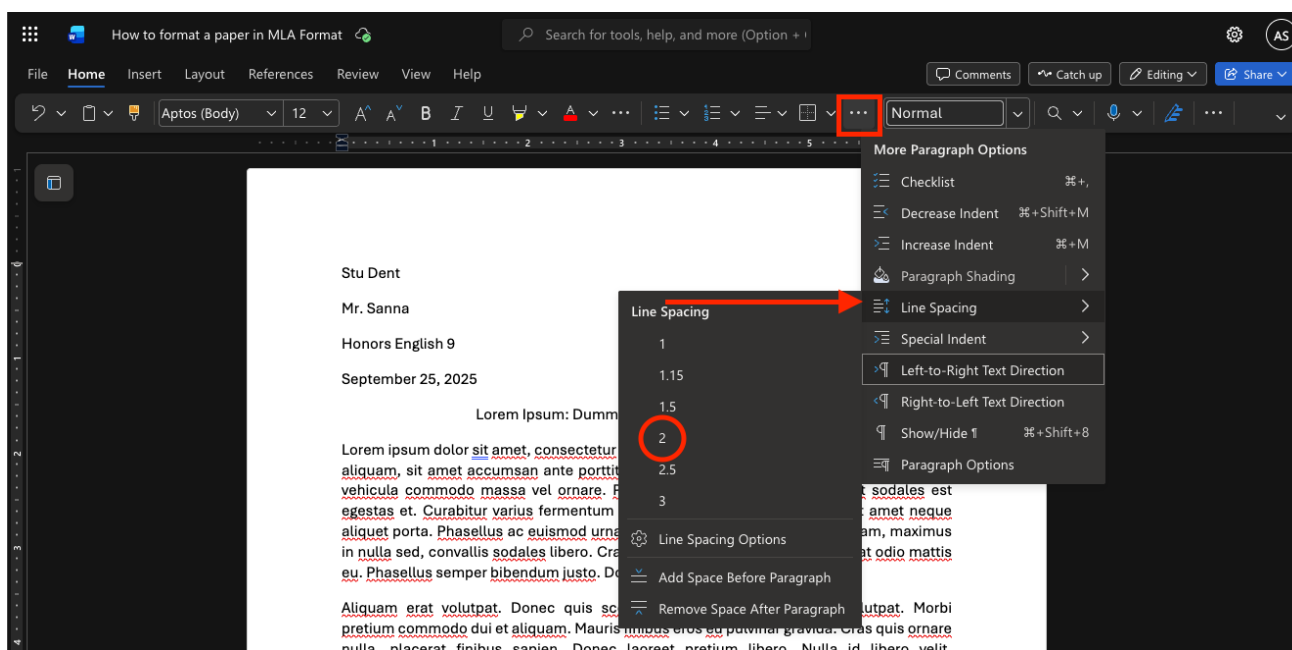
Even though it appears early in your paper, it should be the last thing you come up with. Don't get hung up on creating a title.

Double Space

Double spacing a paper makes it easier to read and allows teachers to write notes in between the lines. Everything in an MLA formatted paper will be double spaced. **Do not add an extra space between paragraphs or lines by pressing “Enter” on your keyboard twice.**

Once your paper is written:

1. Press the “Ctrl” + “A” keys on your keyboard at the same time. This will select all the text in your document.
2. Navigate to the line spacing option on the toolbar. Select “2” from the line spacing options
 - a. Note: Make sure you are in the “Home” tab of the menu. You will also need to click the  button to show the line spacing options.



All text should be evenly double spaced, with no additional blank space between paragraphs.

Indenting Each Paragraph

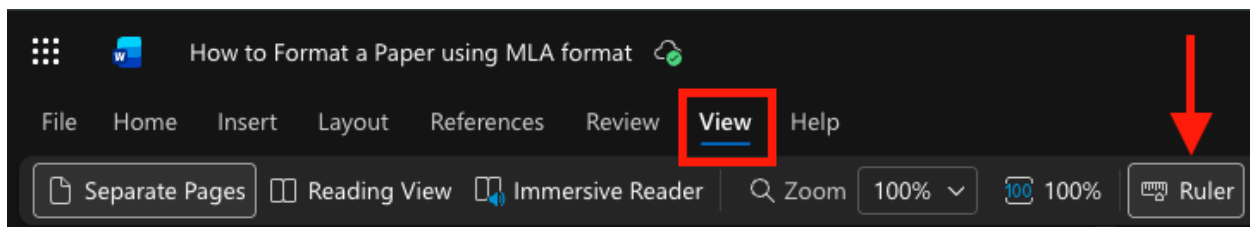
Each new paragraph needs to be indented by one “Tab” press. *Sometimes, teachers will say to indent each paragraph by pressing the space bar five times, but this is incorrect.*

Move your cursor to the start of each paragraph and press Tab. It is good practice to get in the habit of pressing Tab whenever you start new paragraphs, and Word will learn this behavior and automatically indent each new paragraph after the first few.

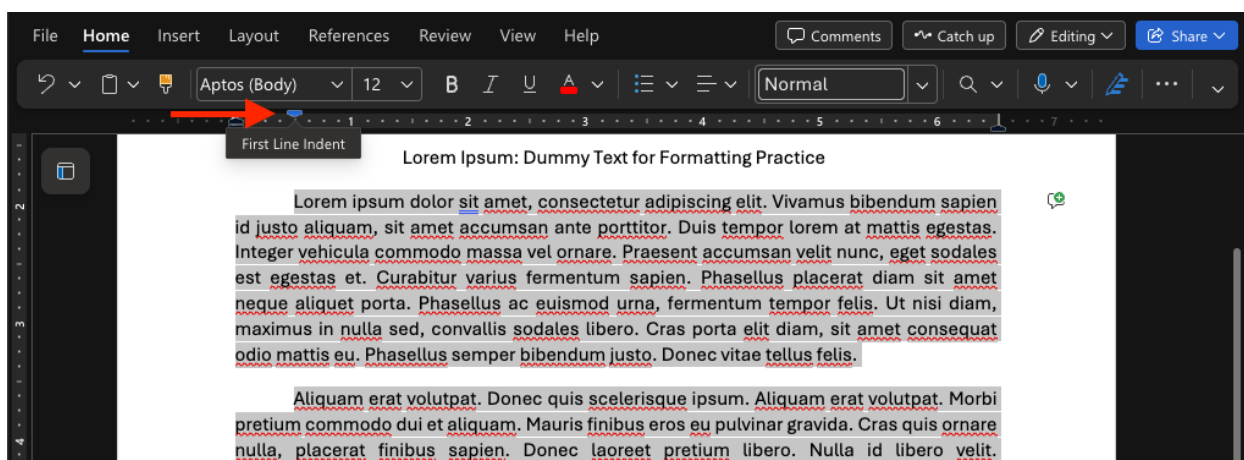


Alternatively, you can use the Ruler function at the top of the document to indent the first line of each paragraph by 0.5 inches.

1. Select “View” from the top toolbar.
2. Then select the “Ruler” option



3. Use your mouse to select all your body paragraphs. Then, click and drag the “First Line Indent” arrow to the “0.50” inch point on the ruler.

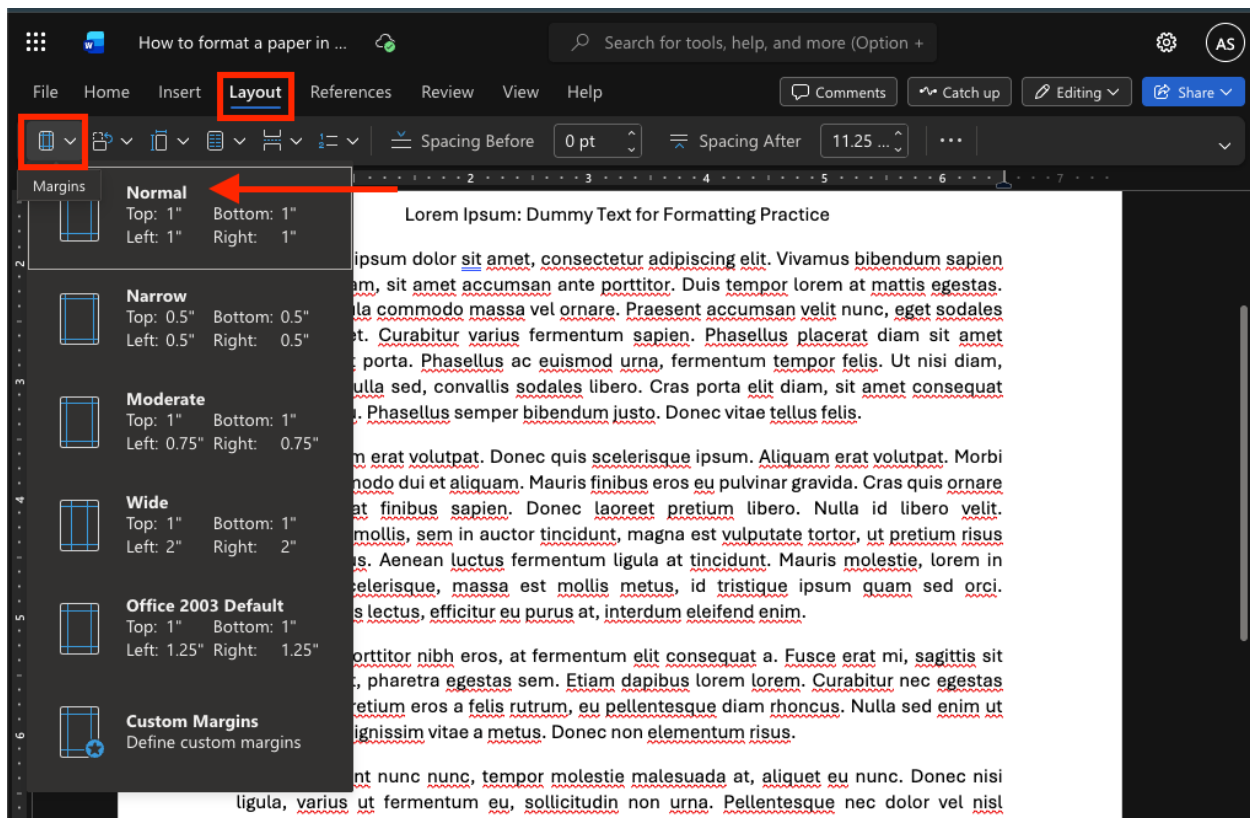


1 Inch Margins

Did you make any changes to the margins of your paper? No? Then you're all good! The standard margins of any new Word document are 1 inch.

To verify your margins:

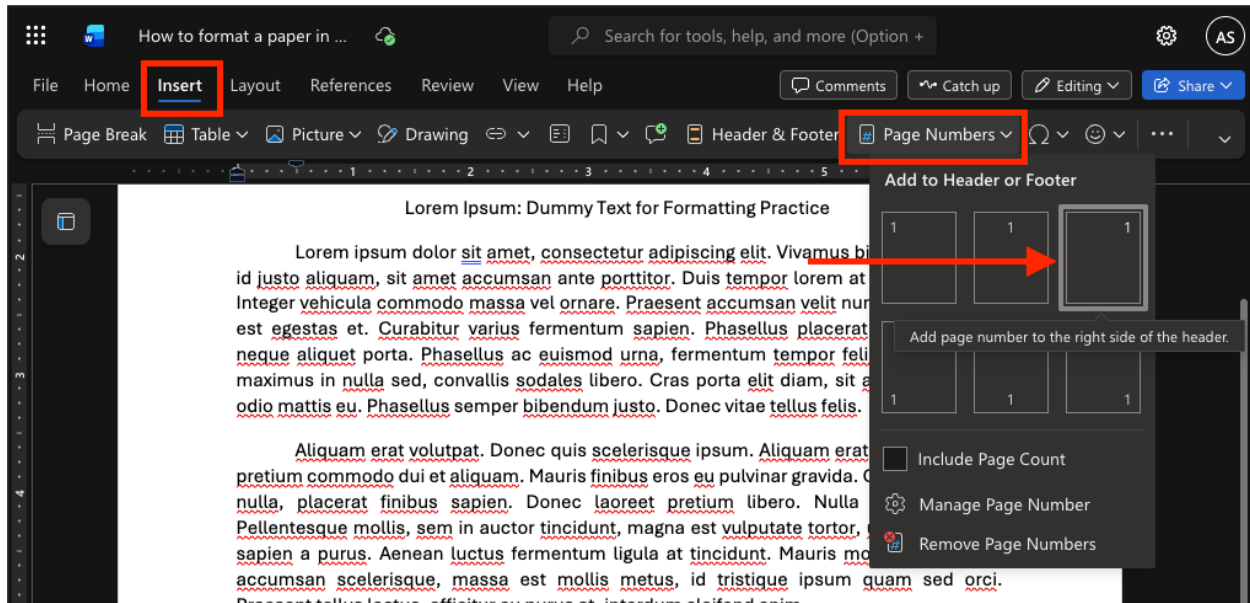
1. Select the "Layout" tab in the top toolbar
2. Select the "Margins" option; it's the first icon in the row
3. Confirm that "Normal" (1 inch on all sides) is selected



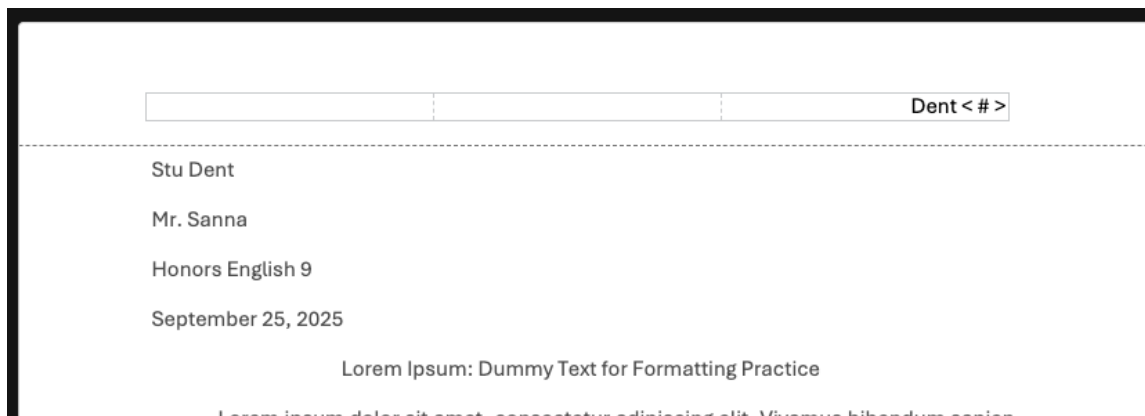
Page Numbers in the Header

Each page should be marked with your last name and the Page Number in the top right corner.

1. Click the “Insert” tab on the toolbar at the top of the document.
2. Select the “Page Numbers” drop down menu.
3. Select the 3rd option. This will put the page number at the top right corner of every page.



4. Double-click the page number. Move your cursor to the left side of the number, then type your last name.
 - a. Make sure the font of your name matches the rest of your document.



Your last name and page number should now appear in the upper-right corner of every page.

And that's basically it. If you follow this checklist as the last step before submitting your papers to Turnitin, you will earn full credit for that portion of the Rubric. Use the following checklist to verify that you followed all the steps before submitting:

- ☐ My heading contains all four required lines.
- ☐ My title is centered and uses normal text formatting.
- ☐ My entire document is double-spaced.
- ☐ There are no extra blank lines between paragraphs.
- ☐ Every paragraph begins with a 0.5-inch indent.
- ☐ My margins are 1 inch.
- ☐ My last name and page number appear in the upper-right corner.

If every box is checked, your paper is ready to submit.

If you need help or would like me to review your paper for these formatting issues, share the document with your teacher and add a note with your request/question, or ask them to review your document while in class.